

crease of posts or a cadre review which it is fast becoming now," says Singh. The contentious figure of 156 senior posts, to be distributed amongst the three services, was only meant to be an outer limit and not an absolute figure. It was to be implemented over five years as part of a package of measures designed to ease stagnation within the upper echelons of the services. Yet, it has now turned into a nasty scramble for posts. "Where is the army going to accommodate so many additional generals?" asks a MOD official.

The army points to the current vice-chief of naval staff being two years junior to the vice-chief of army staff as an example of why increasing the brasshats in the two other services will

only lead to more peer frustration. It suggests the two other services add only two posts equivalent to Lt General, instead of seven.

Defence analyst K. Subrahmanyam terms the fight unfortunate and one that is belittling high ranks. "Rather than this silly lopsided rationing out of senior ranks, the services should actually be speaking of the posts which will have officers of a certain rank," he says.

Antony plays down the rift saying he sees nothing wrong in the individual services putting forth their claims. "We will find a solution soon," he says.

It is easier said than done. The genesis of the problem lies in the steep pyramid which characterises the armed forces, particularly the army, which leads to severe frustration. Only three out of 100 army officers reach the rank of Major General. In sharp contrast, 90 out of 100 IAS officers reach the equivalent rank of joint-secretary. Part of the Singh committee's recommendations aimed at making an army career more attractive to young officers and then allow them to leave after 10 years, equipping them for a successful second career on civvy street. Yet nobody is talking about the committee's radical long-term goals. It spoke of reversing the ratio between career officers from the National Defence Academy (NDA) and short service commissioned officers. Unlike armies elsewhere, only a fraction of the 1,300 officers the army recruits annually are short-service commissioned officers. A radical voluntary severance scheme formed part of the committee's efforts aimed at increasing the 'peel factor' or whittling down the number of officers rising up the pyramid.

The air force and the navy say the army chief is trying to cut them down to size. Earlier, alluding to the army's role in manning the borders and fighting insurgency, General Singh said the concept of a Chief of Defence Staff (CDS)—a four-star officer to whom all the three service chiefs will report—was a futuristic concept when the current challenges before the nation were 'single-service' specific. A feature of every major global military power, a CDS will meld the three services into an effective fighting force. The post, to be held in rotation by the three services, is yet to be approved owing to a lack of

consensus or unanimity among the services. IAF is bitterly opposed to it as it fears army domination. The numerically-larger army does not want to take orders from a non-army chief. Analysts feel the army's dogged opposition to the second phase of the committee's recommendations stems out of a desire to retain its pre-eminence in a changing military scenario where the role of armies is set to diminish.

"With nuclear weapons ruling out inter-state warfare, the role of the navy and the air force has acquired greater salience," emphasises air vice-marshal (retired) Kapil Kak of the Centre for Air Power Studies. The army argues that the present challenges before the country—insurgency and manning disputed

"The recommendations were not meant to become a one-time increase of senior posts in the forces."

A.V. SINGH, FORMER DEFENCE SECRETARY

boundaries—which call for boots on the ground, remain army-specific.

With the current turf war, prospects of a CDS have further receded. Last month, Antony sent out a letter to various political parties asking for their views on the issue of CDS, first recommended by a group of ministers in 2001. He was only repeating an exercise started by his predecessors as the Government aims at building a 'political consensus' on the decision. The truth is that neither the political establishment nor the bureaucracy is comfortable with vesting too much power in the hands of an armed forces official. This exercise is being seen as a mere academic one, the bureaucratic equivalent of putting a file in orbit.

With the defence minister asking the three chiefs to amicably resolve the logjam over senior posts, there are signs of a compromise formula being hammered out. However, the damage to the edifice of jointmanship seems to have already been done. As the Government debates over a CDS and the defence ministry mandarins mediate the dispute, they could well ask whether the services are themselves ready to fight jointly. ■



NAVY CHIEF: Admiral Suresh Mehta



NAVY PRESENT STRENGTH

NO. OF OFFICERS: 10,563

**PROPOSED INCREASE 7 Vice-Admirals,
16 Rear Admirals**